

Madawaska/Edmundston International Bridge and Border Crossing Feasibility and Planning Study

Final SEIS

I included the Executive Summary of the Final SEIS and Section 4(f) Evaluation, the whole document is approximately 500 pages. I developed the Executive Summary from the final copy of the document, collecting the relevant information and meeting the requirements of the National Environmental Policy Act (NEPA). In this document I was responsible for: the layout in InDesign; creation of many of the maps and graphics using Photoshop, Illustrator, and raw ArcGIS files; creating the Executive Summary and Abstract from the body of the report; final editing and proofing; and ensuring all references were accurate, up to date, and used properly.

The Madawaska/Edmundston International Bridge and Border Crossing project began in the spring of 2017 and continued through the Feasibility Study to a Draft Supplemental Environmental Impact Statement (SEIS) and Programmatic Section 4(f) Evaluation (2018), a Final SEIS and Programmatic Section 4(f) Evaluation (2019), and a Record of Decision (ROD) (2020).

New Madawaska U.S. Land Port of Entry and International Bridge Project

*Madawaska, Aroostook County, Maine to
Edmundston, New Brunswick, Canada*



Final Supplemental Environmental Impact Statement and Final Programmatic Section 4(f) Evaluation

**U.S. General Services Administration, Region 1
Federal Highway Administration**

FHWA-ME-EIS-18-01-F

August 2019

Federal Co-Lead Agencies:



State Lead Agency:



Cooperating Agency:



In coordination with U.S. Customs and Border Protection, the New Brunswick Department of Transportation and Infrastructure, Public Services and Procurement Canada, and the Canada Border Services Agency

New Madawaska U.S. Land Port of Entry and International Bridge Project

Final Supplemental Environmental Impact Statement and Final Programmatic Section 4(f) Evaluation

U.S. General Services Administration, Federal Highway Administration, and Maine Department of Transportation

FHWA-ME-EIS-18-01-F

August 2019

In Cooperation with the U.S. Coast Guard

In Coordination with U.S. Customs and Border Protection, the New Brunswick Department of Transportation and Infrastructure,
Public Services and Procurement Canada, and the Canada Border Services Agency

The U.S. General Services Administration (GSA), the Federal Highway Administration (FHWA), and the Maine Department of Transportation (MaineDOT), in cooperation with the U.S. Coast Guard (USCG), and in coordination with U.S. Customs and Border Protection (CBP), the New Brunswick Department of Transportation and Infrastructure (NBDTI), Public Services and Procurement Canada (PSPC), and the Canada Border Services Agency (CBSA), propose to replace the existing U.S. Land Port of Entry (LPOE) and the existing International Bridge in Madawaska, Aroostook County, Maine, and Edmundston, New Brunswick, Canada, with a new LPOE and International Bridge to improve safety, security, and functionality. The existing LPOE facilities are undersized and obsolete, and consequently incapable of allowing the federal agencies assigned to the LPOE to fulfill their missions efficiently. The existing International Bridge is nearing the end of its useful life and has been restricted to vehicles weighing under five tons. The project consists of the likely demolition or decommissioning of the existing LPOE and International Bridge, and the construction of a new LPOE facility, and a proposed bridge replacement. This Final Supplemental Environmental Impact Statement (FSEIS) evaluates a No-Build Alternative and several build alternatives for the LPOE and the International Bridge Project and identifies a preferred alternative.


Glenn C. Rotondo

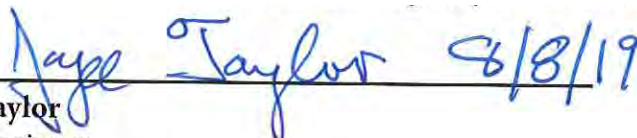
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**Comments on this Final Supplemental Environmental Impact Statement are due
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Summary

A. Introduction

1. Background

It is widely recognized that the International Bridge connecting Edmundston, New Brunswick and Madawaska, Maine is functionally obsolete, nearing the end of its useful life, and in need of rehabilitation or replacement (Exhibit S.1). Underscoring the need to rehabilitate or replace the International Bridge, the Maine Department of Transportation (MaineDOT) and New Brunswick Department of Transportation and Infrastructure (NBDTI) posted the International Bridge at five tons (the equivalent of a passenger vehicle) in October 2017. It is further recognized that the size and conditions of the existing building and overall site of the existing Madawaska Land Port of Entry (LPOE) are substandard, preventing the agencies assigned to the LPOE from adequately fulfilling their missions (Exhibit S.2).

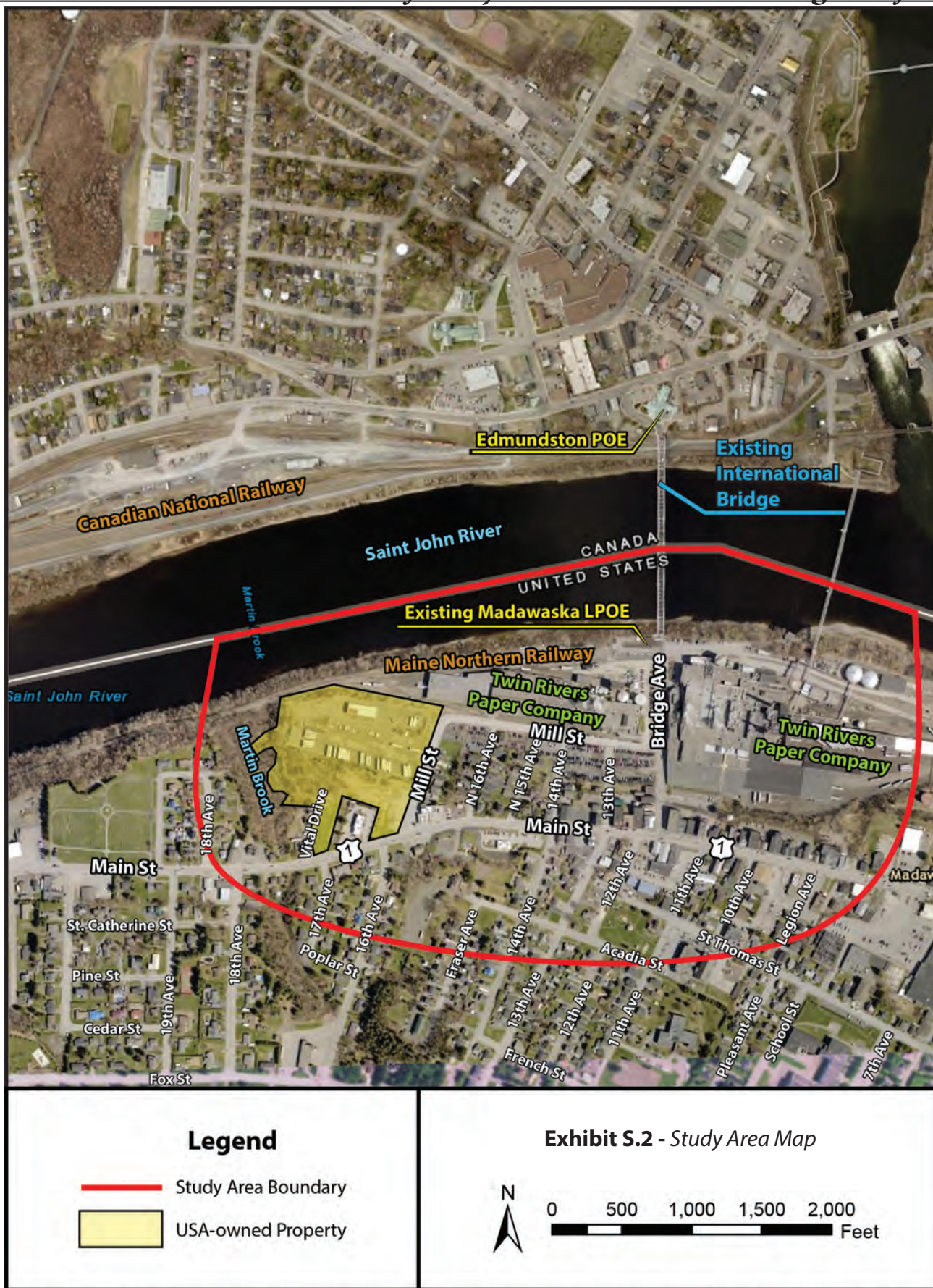
In response, the federal, provincial, and state agencies responsible for the movement of people and goods across this international crossing initiated in 2017 the preparation of the *Madawaska/Edmundston International Bridge and Border Crossing Feasibility and Planning Study* (MEFPS) to identify a preferred location for the rehabilitation or replacement of the International Bridge and Madawaska LPOE.

After identifying the preferred location, the MEFPS led directly to the Draft Supplemental Environmental Impact Statement (DSEIS) for the New Madawaska LPOE and International Bridge, which was followed by this Final Supplemental Environmental Impact Statement (FSEIS). Replacing the Madawaska LPOE was considered by the U.S. General Services Administration (GSA) in 2006 and 2007 and an environmental impact statement (EIS) was prepared. After the publication of the 2007 FEIS and ROD, the GSA chose not to advance the replacement of the Madawaska LPOE due to a number of factors.

The condition of the existing International Bridge has continued to deteriorate. The GSA and the Federal Highway Administration (FHWA), acting as joint lead federal agencies, and the MaineDOT as the state lead agency, in cooperation with the United States Coast Guard (USCG), and in coordination with the U.S. Customs and Border Protection (CBP), NBDTI, Public Services and Procurement Canada (PSPC), and the Canada Border Services Agency (CBSA), propose to replace the existing Madawaska LPOE facility and the existing International Bridge in Madawaska, Aroostook County, Maine, and Edmundston, New Brunswick, Canada, with a new LPOE and International Bridge to improve safety, security, and functionality.



New Madawaska U.S. Land Port of Entry and International Bridge Project



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2. Project Description

The proposed project consists of the likely demolition or decommissioning of the existing Madawaska LPOE and the demolition of the existing International Bridge; the construction of a new LPOE consisting of a main administration building and support buildings with parking, circulation, and processing areas; and the construction of a new International Bridge. The new LPOE would be designed in accordance with the requirements and criteria of the GSA and the CBP to provide facilities adequate for fulfilling the agencies' respective missions. The new International Bridge would be designed in accordance with MaineDOT standards with a design life of at least 75 years.

The existing International Bridge carries utility lines operated by Twin Rivers Paper Company (Twin Rivers) across the Saint John River. These lines would be relocated, and the existing International Bridge would be demolished.

As part of the construction of the LPOE, the portions of Mill Street and Main Street adjacent to the LPOE may be reconstructed or reprofiled to provide smooth ingress and egress to the LPOE.

3. Purpose and Need

The purpose of this project is to provide for the long-term safe and efficient flow of current and projected traffic volumes, including the movement of goods and people, between Madawaska, Maine and Edmundston, New Brunswick.

The proposed project is needed because: 1) the existing International Bridge is nearing the end of its useful life, and 2) the size and conditions of the existing building and overall site of the Madawaska LPOE are substandard, preventing the agencies assigned to the LPOE from adequately fulfilling their respective missions (MaineDOT, et al., 2018).

a. Existing Madawaska Land Port of Entry

The Madawaska LPOE is situated on approximately 0.87 acre and has many deficiencies and physical limitations. The size and conditions of the existing building and overall site are substandard, preventing the agencies assigned to the LPOE from adequately fulfilling their respective missions. The deficiencies with the existing facilities have led to extensive traffic delays for vehicles entering the U.S.

b. Existing International Bridge is Nearing the End of its Useful Life

The International Bridge is a 928-foot-long four-span bridge carrying Bridge Avenue over the Saint John River. Originally built in 1920, each span consists of a Pennsylvania Truss measuring 232 feet long with a roadway width of 20 feet, 8 inches (MaineDOT, 2017a).

After nearly 100 years of service, the overall bridge is in poor condition. Despite efforts to maintain the bridge, the rate of deterioration has accelerated to the point

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that the end of the useful service life of the bridge is fast approaching. In October 2017, the bridge was posted at five tons (the equivalent of a passenger vehicle). Further attempts to repair or rehabilitate the bridge will not restore the full capacity of the bridge to meet today's load requirements or geometric standards; hence, any substantial investments would be impractical. Extensive repairs will be needed in the future on a more frequent basis to maintain the usefulness of the structure, albeit in a reduced state of functionality.

B. Alternatives

In the GSA's 2007 Final Environmental Impact Statement and Record of Decision, the selected alternative for replacing the LPOE was the construction of a new LPOE to the southwest in the Town of Madawaska's industrial zone. A 1,600-foot-long elevated roadway along the top of the bank of the Saint John River would provide access to the existing International Bridge.

The results of the MEFPS identified a preferred location for the new LPOE and a preferred corridor for the International Bridge that was supported by the GSA, MaineDOT, CBP, NBDTI, PSPC, and the CBSA. Many alternatives, including some that were studied in the 2007 Final Environmental Impact Statement and other studies, were identified and 12 were developed and analyzed before a preferred location for the LPOE and a preferred corridor for a proposed International Bridge were identified (Exhibit S.3). As part of developing and analyzing a preferred location for the LPOE and a preferred corridor for a proposed new International Bridge, social, economic, and natural features and potential impacts were taken into consideration and extensive public involvement occurred.

The preferred location for the Madawaska LPOE is a parcel of land, to the west of the existing LPOE and the Twin Rivers facility, that is currently owned by the U.S. government.

The preferred corridor for the new International Bridge connects the USA-owned property to the existing Edmundston Port of Entry (POE), as the PSPC and the CBSA noted that the POE was adequate for the foreseeable future and there are no plans to modify or expand it (MaineDOT, et al., 2018).

Following the identification of a preferred location and corridor, the GSA identified, developed, and analyzed three build alternatives that could potentially satisfy the project's purpose and needs for the LPOE; the FHWA and MaineDOT identified, developed, and analyzed three build alternatives for the new International Bridge. In developing and analyzing alternatives, the GSA, FHWA, and MaineDOT consulted with regulatory and resource agencies at the federal and state levels, local officials, industry, and the public. The alternatives for the LPOE and International Bridge were compared to the No-Build Alternative. After further analysis, a Preferred LPOE Alternative and a Preferred Bridge Alternative were identified.



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1. The No-Build Alternative

The National Environmental Policy Act (NEPA) and other legislation affording the consideration and protection of social, natural, and cultural features require the consideration of a No-Build Alternative. In addition to fulfilling a requirement, discussion of this alternative serves two important purposes: 1) it may be a reasonable alternative, especially where the adverse impacts of a proposed action are high and the need is relatively minor; and 2) the No-Build Alternative serves as a benchmark against which the impacts of the other alternatives can be compared.

Under the No-Build Alternative, operation of the existing LPOE and International Bridge would continue at their existing locations and using the existing facilities. Except for regular maintenance and minor repairs to the existing infrastructure and equipment, no new construction or demolition would take place. No new inspection and travel lanes, facilities, or bridge structure would be built. This alternative would not require the acquisition of private property. The International Bridge would continue to deteriorate, and the posted weight limit would remain in effect.

The No-Build Alternative does not satisfy the project's purpose or needs because, without new construction, there would be no appreciable improvement to the current operating conditions at the LPOE or International Bridge. The CBP and other agencies' staff would continue to operate with inadequate space to efficiently perform their duties and carry out their agencies' missions. Outbound inspection of vehicles and pedestrians would continue to be difficult and hazardous for LPOE staff. The existing International Bridge would continue to deteriorate, the five-ton weight restriction would remain in effect, the amount of time and cost to maintain the bridge would increase, and, eventually, the bridge would become unsafe for use.

2. Madawaska Land Port of Entry

Following the preparation of the 2018 MEFPS, the GSA began further study of the USA-owned property and developed alternatives for the LPOE. The USA-owned property has constraints that were considered in the development of alternatives for the LPOE. The Town of Madawaska has zoned the area along Martin Brook as a resource protection zone and development should be set back 75 feet to help ensure its protection. From Main Street to the area of the proposed International Bridge, the USA-owned property decreases approximately 45 feet in elevation. In the development of the LPOE, the GSA would like to maintain a grade of 2 percent or less (MPdL Studio, 2018).

The build alternatives were designed to meet several key building, processing, and parking area requirements:

- A consolidated administration building.
- Primary inspection areas for commercial traffic (trucks), passenger vehicles, and buses.

- Secondary inspection areas for trucks, passenger vehicles, and buses.
- Adequate number and location of parking spaces.
- Adequate space to accommodate security measures.

Each of the build alternatives was designed to follow the sequential circulation of traffic flow of a LPOE, which requires certain buildings be adjacent to one another. For instance, the primary inspection areas must precede secondary ones. Administration should be consolidated to the extent possible in one building. Parking for visitors and employees should be in a convenient location in proximity to the buildings they serve.

a. Alternative A

Alternative A was developed on the existing USA-owned property with no additional private property (Exhibit S.4). The existing USA-owned property has few opportunities for access to and from Main Street. As a result, outbound and inbound driveways are separated by private property owned by McDonald's ("the McDonald's property"). The outbound driveway is close to the intersection at Mill Street, and the inbound driveway is located between Vital Drive and the exit from the McDonald's property parking lot and drive-through (MPdL Studio, 2018).

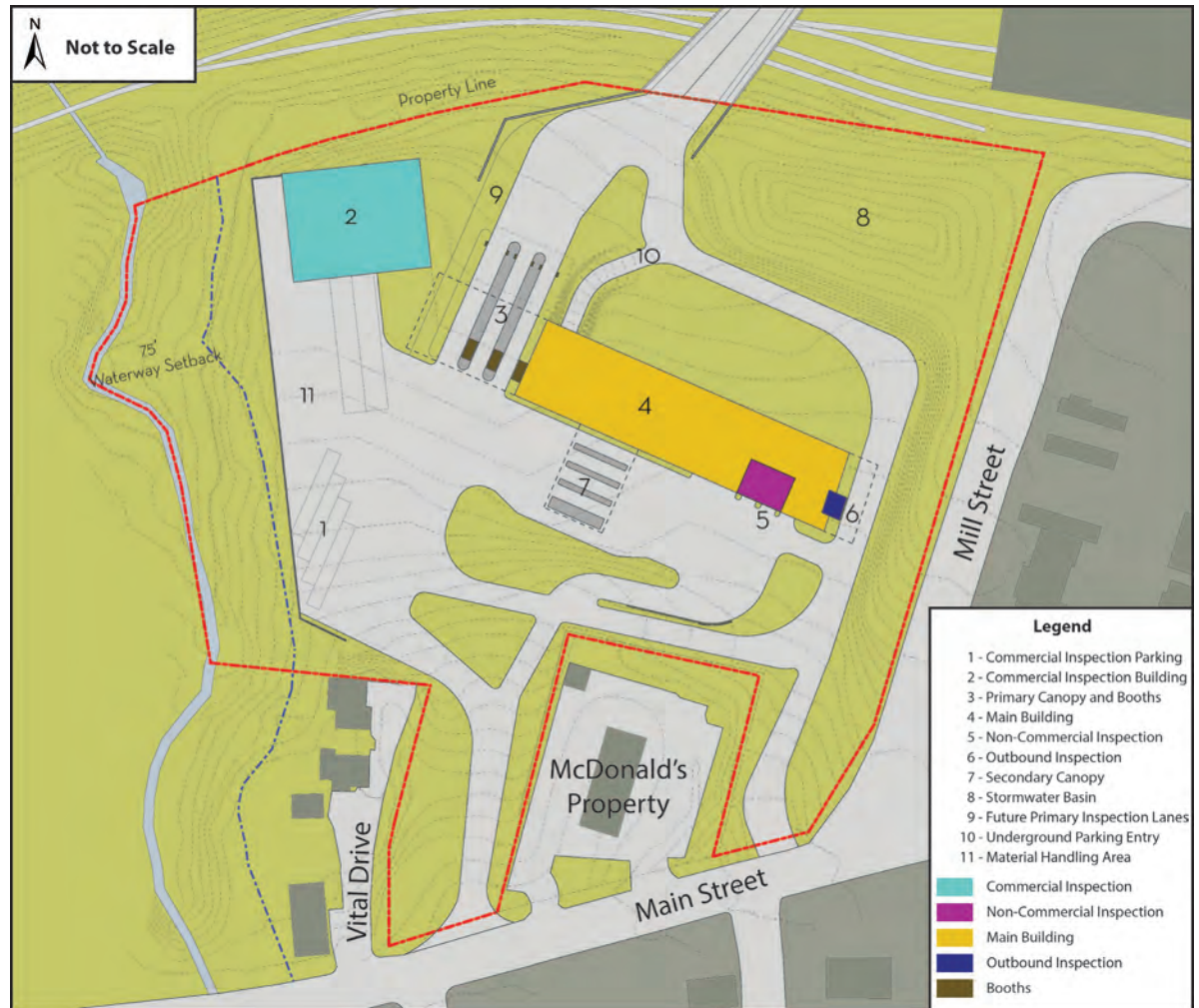
The required distance between a driveway and an unsignalized intersection, as per MaineDOT access management guidelines, should be at least 100 feet from the edge of the existing intersection and the edge of the new driveway. Alternative A does not meet this guideline (MPdL Studio, 2018).

Canadian B-trains (double trailers) would need to travel on Main Street for a short distance, since this alternative does not provide direct access from the USA-owned property to Mill Street. Canadian B-trains are not permitted on Maine State Highways (per Title 29-A MRSA § 2354-C), but they are used frequently by Twin Rivers. Canadian B-trains are only permitted to travel from the United States-Canada border in Madawaska directly north or south into the Twin Rivers facility (or its successor) or south on Bridge Street to Mill Street to reverse direction. Permission and any changes to the approved travel patterns for Canadian B-trains would require a legislative process and approval. Alternative A would require MaineDOT to permit B-trains on Main Street between the new LPOE and Mill Street (MPdL Studio, 2018).

The USA-owned property limits the arrangement of the buildings and parking areas for the LPOE. Most notably, Alternative A would require underground parking to meet the projected parking demands of the LPOE. Visitor parking is not practical. The functionality of the commercial inspection parking is compromised due to limited space. The materials handling area, the commercial inspection staging lot, and the impound lot are in proximity to one another, resulting in vehicle conflicts (MPdL Studio, 2018).

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Exhibit S.4 - Madawaska LPOE Alternative A



Source: MPdL Studio, 2018

Alternative A has approximately 60 percent of the open space necessary to accommodate seasonal snow storage (MPdL Studio, 2018).

After careful consideration and comparison to the other alternatives for the LPOE, Alternative A was dismissed from further consideration because:

- The entrance to the LPOE does not meet MaineDOT's access management guidelines and would not be approved by MaineDOT.
- The exit from the LPOE to Main Street, between Vital Drive and the exit from the McDonald's restaurant property, has limited visibility in both directions on Main Street, does not meet MaineDOT's access management guidelines, and would not be approved by MaineDOT.
- The location of the outbound and inbound driveways in proximity to other driveways and an intersection raises safety concerns, particularly in the context of historical motor vehicle crash data at the intersection of Mill Street and in front of McDonald's.

- Canadian B-trains would need to travel on Main Street for a short distance. Canadian B-trains are not permitted to travel on Main Street (per Title 29-A MRSA § 2354-C). Canadian B-trains are only permitted to travel from the United States-Canada border in Madawaska directly north or south into the Twin Rivers facility (or its successor) or south on Bridge Street to Mill Street to reverse direction. Permission and any changes to the approved travel patterns for Canadian B-trains would require a legislative process and approval.
- The property does not have enough space to permit the operations of the LPOE to function efficiently.
- The property does not have enough space for parking.
- The property has only approximately 60 percent of the open space necessary to accommodate seasonal snow storage.
- The property does not have enough open space to accommodate the necessary length of road to descend from the bridge landing elevation (538) to the elevation of Mill Street (520) without a steep road grade of approximately 11 percent. Road grades may be no higher than 5 percent, and 2 percent in some locations to comply with MaineDOT civil highway standards, and to allow safe maintenance and circulation in winter conditions.
- The property does not have space for future expansion.
- The direct proximity of private and commercial properties to the new LPOE poses safety and security risks to CBP's mission and operations, along with line of site and traffic impedance issues. The Government and the community would be better served if those properties were incorporated into the LPOE site (MPdL Studio, 2018).

b. Alternative B

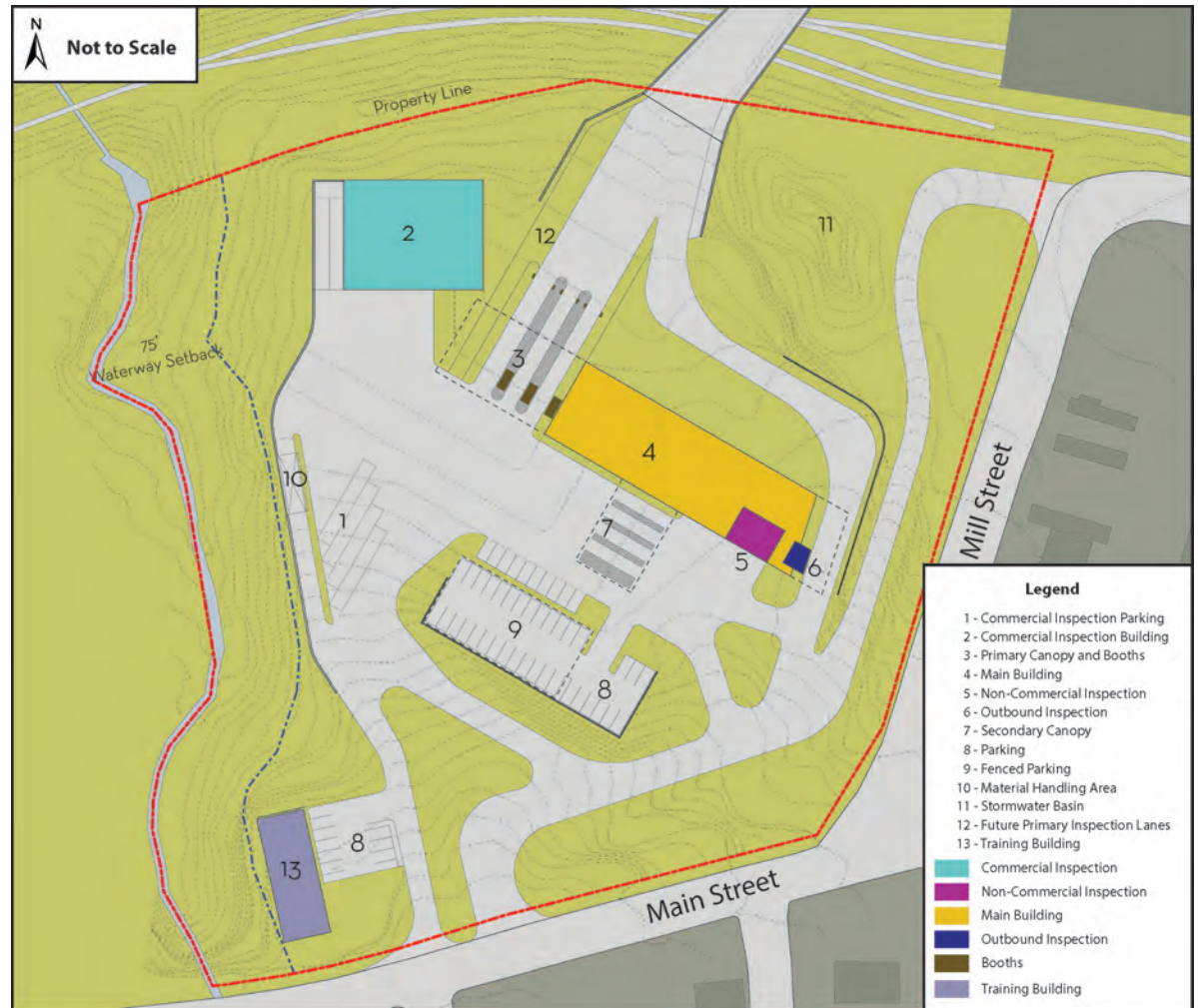
Alternative B requires the acquisition of additional private property (Exhibit S.5). Several options were pursued, exploring the acquisition of only the McDonald's property and/or the Vital Drive properties. GSA concluded that acquiring these two sets of properties had substantial benefit for the flow of traffic and pedestrians around and through the new LPOE. Therefore, Alternative B would require the acquisition of the McDonald's property and the three Vital Drive properties (MPdL Studio, 2018).

Alternative B allows for improved visibility for vehicles entering and exiting the new LPOE as well as favorable locations for ingress and egress from Main Street. The outbound driveway is more than 100 feet away from the intersection of Mill Street and Main Street which reduces the potential for vehicle crashes and safety concerns (MPdL Studio, 2018).

Alternative B provides direct inbound access from the USA-owned property to Mill Street, reducing traffic on Main Street. Given the additional land, Alternative B accommodates the necessary length of road to descend from the bridge landing elevation to Mill Street without a steep grade of approximately 11 percent. Road grades may be no higher than 5 percent, and 2 percent in some locations to comply

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Exhibit S.5 - Madawaska LPOE Alternative B



Source: MPdL Studio, 2018

with MaineDOT civil highway standards, and to allow safe maintenance and circulation in winter conditions.

Alternative B does not include a direct outbound connection to Mill Street. Alternative B would require MaineDOT to permit Canadian B-trains to use Main Street between Mill Street and the new LPOE (MPdL Studio, 2018). Canadian B-trains are not permitted to travel on Main Street (per Title 29-A MRSA § 2354-C). Canadian B-trains are only permitted to travel from the United States-Canada border in Madawaska directly north or south into the Twin Rivers facility (or its successor) or south on Bridge Street to Mill Street to reverse direction. Permission and any changes to the approved travel patterns for Canadian B-trains would require a legislative process and approval.

Alternative B has space for all necessary LPOE activities, flow of traffic, and snow storage (MPdL Studio, 2018).

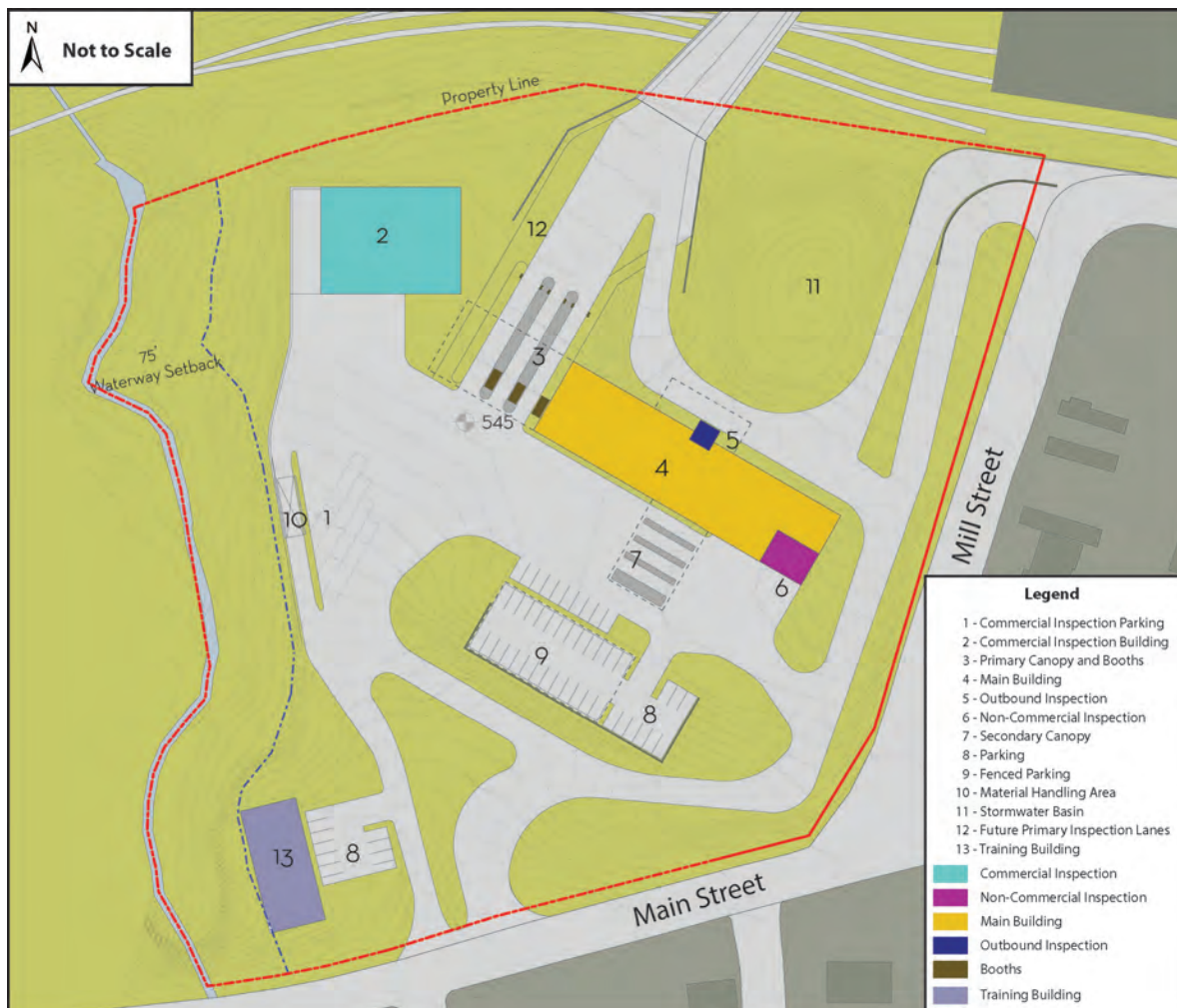
After careful consideration and comparison to the other alternatives for the LPOE, Alternative B was dismissed from further consideration because Canadian B-trains, destined for New Brunswick, would need to travel on Main Street for a short distance (MPdL Studio, 2018).

Canadian B-trains are not permitted to travel on Main Street (per Title 29-A MRSA § 2354-C). Canadian B-trains are only permitted to travel from the United States-Canada border in Madawaska directly north or south into the Twin Rivers facility (or its successor) or south on Bridge Street to Mill Street to reverse direction. Permission and any changes to the approved travel patterns for Canadian B-trains would require a legislative process and approval.

c. Alternative C

Alternative C requires the acquisition of additional private property (Exhibit S.6) (MPdL Studio, 2018). Alternative C would require the acquisition of the McDonald's property and the three Vital Drive properties (MPdL Studio, 2018).

Exhibit S.6 - Madawaska LPOE Alternative C



Source: MPdL Studio, 2018

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Alternative C allows for improved visibility for vehicles entering and exiting the new LPOE. The outbound driveway is more than 100 feet from the intersection of Mill Street and Main Street, which reduces the potential for vehicle crashes and safety concerns (MPdL Studio, 2018).

Alternative C provides direct inbound and outbound access to and from the USA-owned property to Mill Street. Given the additional land, Alternative C accommodates the necessary length of road to descend and ascend from the bridge landing elevation to Mill Street without a steep grade. This would enable Canadian B-trains, not permitted on Maine State Highways but frequently used by Twin Rivers, to access Mill Street, both inbound and outbound (MPdL Studio, 2018).

Alternative C has space for all necessary LPOE activities, flow of traffic, and snow storage (MPdL Studio, 2018).

LPOE Alternative C was identified as the Preferred Alternative.

3. *International Bridge*

Conceptual bridge alternatives were developed and evaluated.

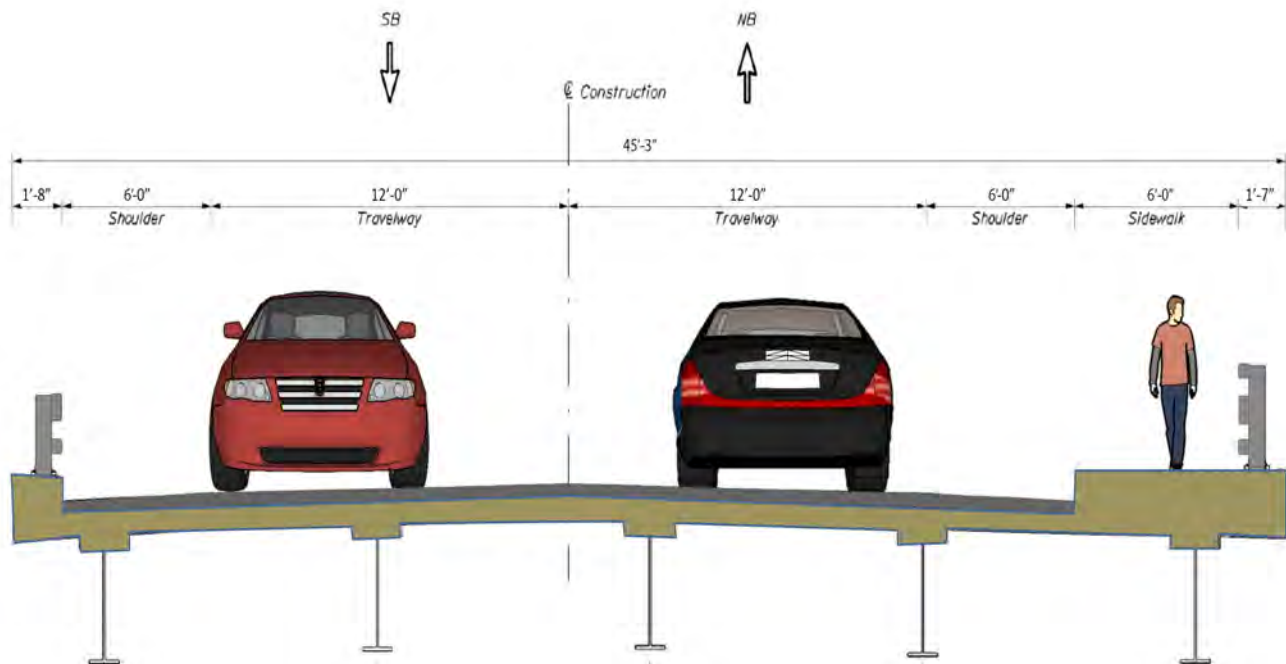
It is recognized that bridges with fewer spans have greater girder/concrete depths. These larger structure depths may unacceptably reduce clearances over the Maine Northern Railway (MNR) and Canadian National Railway (CNR) rail lines. Conversely, increasing the number of spans would require the construction of additional piers which would increase in-stream construction, the potential for ice jams, and construction costs.

Based on these considerations, the construction of a steel girder or segmental concrete bridge with either five, six, or seven spans was selected. Additional options consisting of steel tub girders and precast segmental concrete were briefly considered but dismissed after being judged less desirable based on the proposed bridge size, geometry, and constraints during construction.

Each of the bridge alternatives shares the following features:

- The bridge typical section (Exhibit S.7).
- The horizontal bridge alignment.
- The vertical alignment for the bridge generally decreases from north to south, maintaining minimum vertical clearance required over the MNR and CNR rail lines.
- Stub or cantilever abutments between the LPOE and POE facilities and the adjacent railroad tracks.
- Portions of the bridge ends would be flared to accommodate the turning movements of large trucks.

Exhibit S.7 - Cross Section of the International Bridge

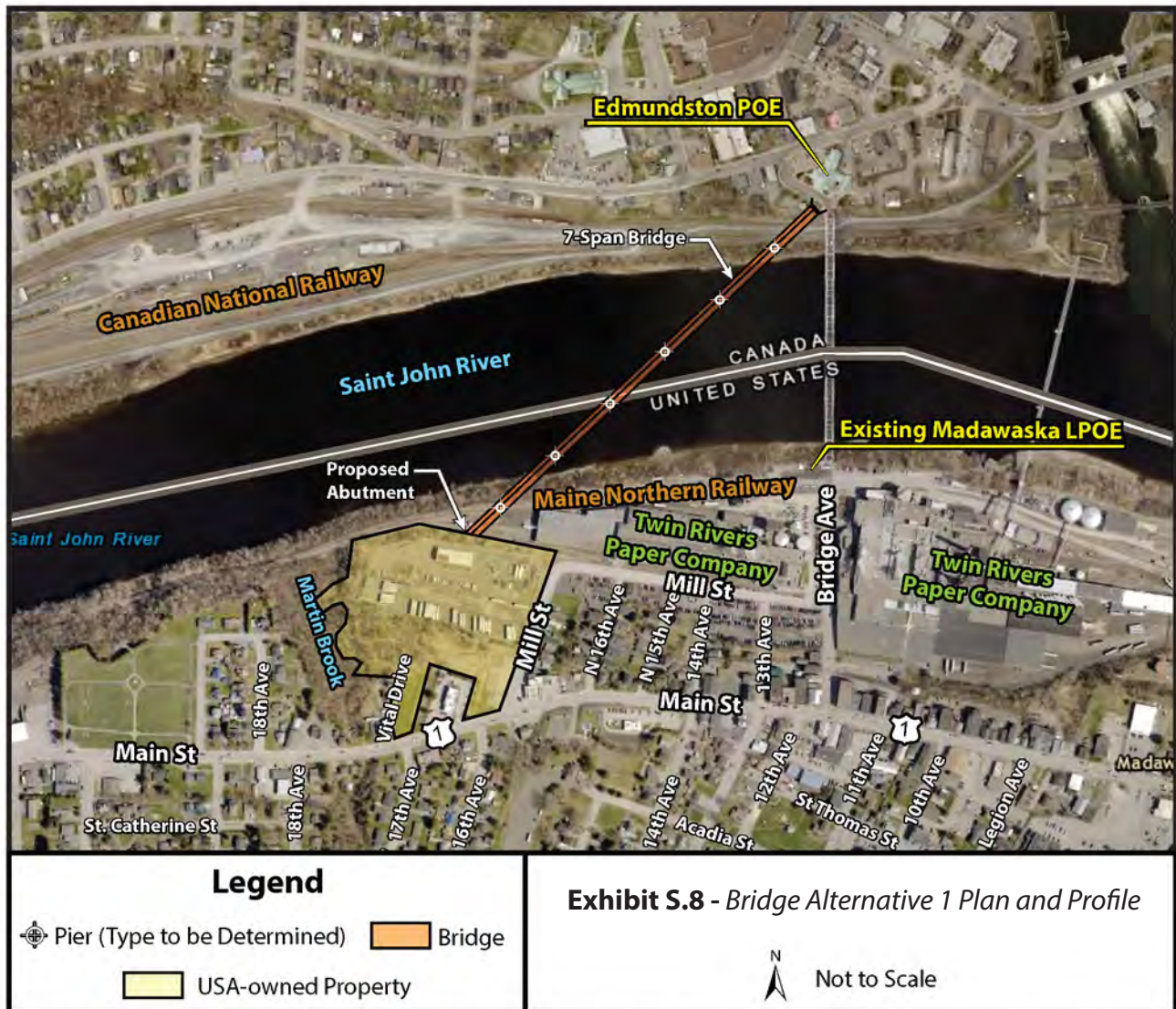
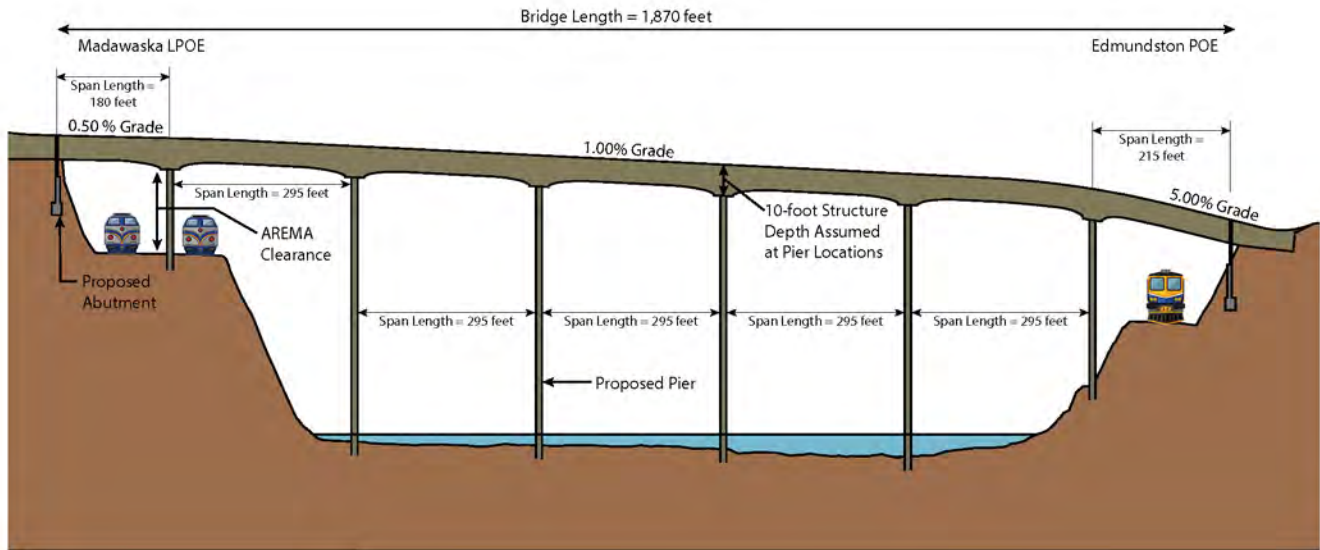


- Access roads along the banks of the Saint John River and a temporary work trestle or rock causeway traversing portions of the river would be necessary to complete construction of the piers and portions of the superstructure.
- a. Bridge Alternative 1: Cast-in-place Segmental Concrete Bridge with Five Spans
- Bridge Alternative 1 consists of the construction of a cast-in-place segmental concrete bridge with five spans (Exhibit S.8). Bridge Alternative 1 is approximately 1,870 feet in length with two 320-foot spans at either end and three 410-foot interior spans. Of the four piers needed, one would be on the bank of the Saint John River in Madawaska, two would be in the Saint John River, and one would be near the bottom of the riverbank in Edmundston.

The vertical profile for Bridge Alternative 1 is governed by the required clearance over the MNR and CNR rail lines and the need to tie into the new Madawaska LPOE and the existing Edmundston POE.

Bridge Alternative 1 was eliminated from further study. Although Bridge Alternative 1 would have one less pier in the Saint John River, the piers to support the bridge would be wider than those with Bridge Alternative 2, increasing the risks for ice jamming in the river. While Bridge Alternative 1 would have similar construction impacts and comparable costs (both construction and long-term operation and maintenance) to Bridge Alternative 2, Bridge Alternative 1 would take approximately six months longer to construct than Bridge Alternative 2.

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b. Bridge Alternative 2: Steel Plate Girder Bridge with Six Spans

Bridge Alternative 2 consists of the construction of a steel girder bridge with six spans (Exhibit S.9). Bridge Alternative 2 is approximately 1,840 feet in length with two 260-foot spans at either end and four 330-foot interior spans. Of the five piers needed, one would be near the top of the riverbank in Madawaska, three piers would be in the river, and one would be near the bottom of the riverbank in Edmundston.

The vertical profile for Bridge Alternative 2 is governed by the required clearance over the CNR rail lines and the need to tie into the new Madawaska LPOE and the existing Edmundston POE.

Bridge Alternative 2 was identified as the Preferred Bridge Alternative.

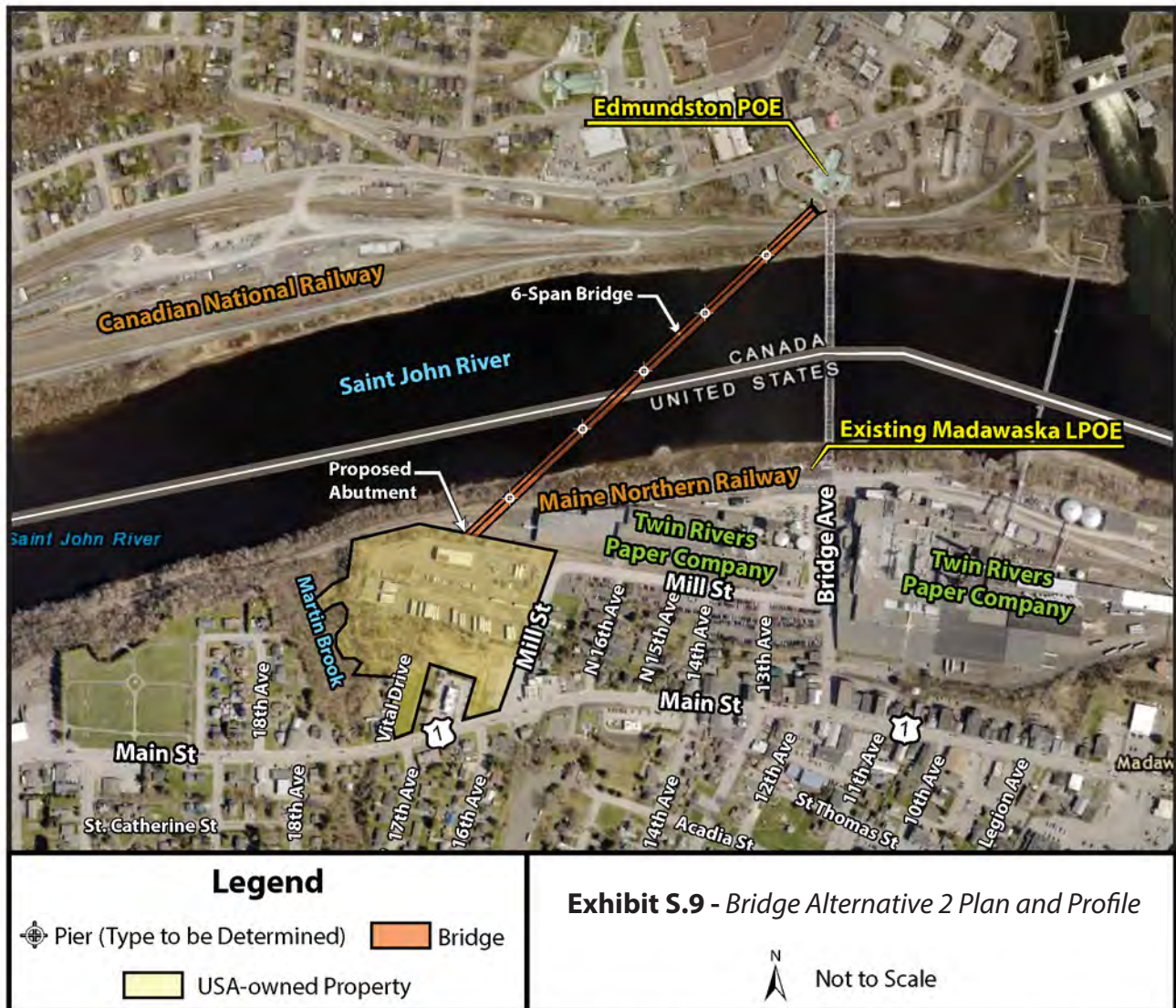
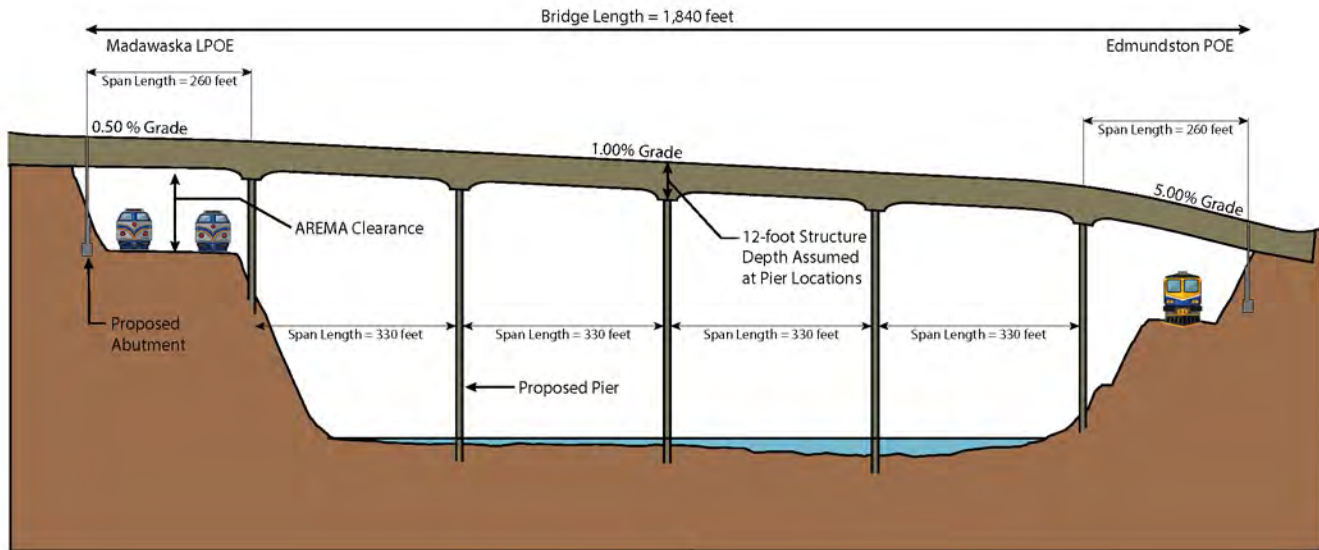
c. Bridge Alternative 3: Steel Plate Girder Bridge with Seven Spans

Bridge Alternative 3 consists of the construction of a steel girder bridge with seven spans (Exhibit S.10). Bridge Alternative 3 is similar to Bridge Alternative 2 but has an additional pier and span to reduce span lengths, reduce girder depths, and generally improve the shipment and erection of the steel girders. Bridge Alternative 3 is approximately 1,870 feet in length with a span of 180 feet connecting to the new Madawaska LPOE, a span of 215 feet connecting to the Edmundston POE, and five 295-foot interior spans. Of the six piers needed, one would be positioned between the MNR railroad tracks in Madawaska, four piers would be in the river, and one would be on the riverbank in Edmundston.

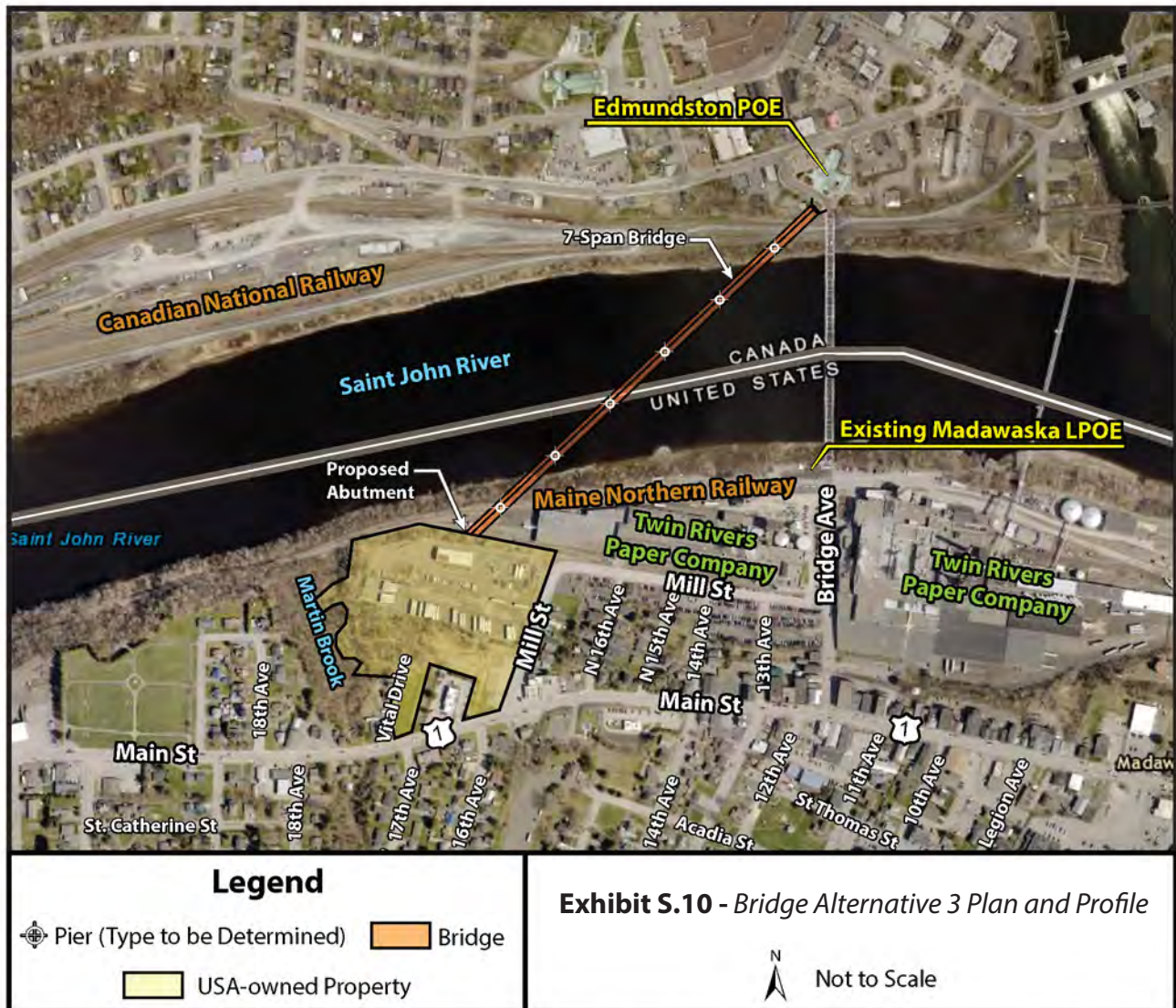
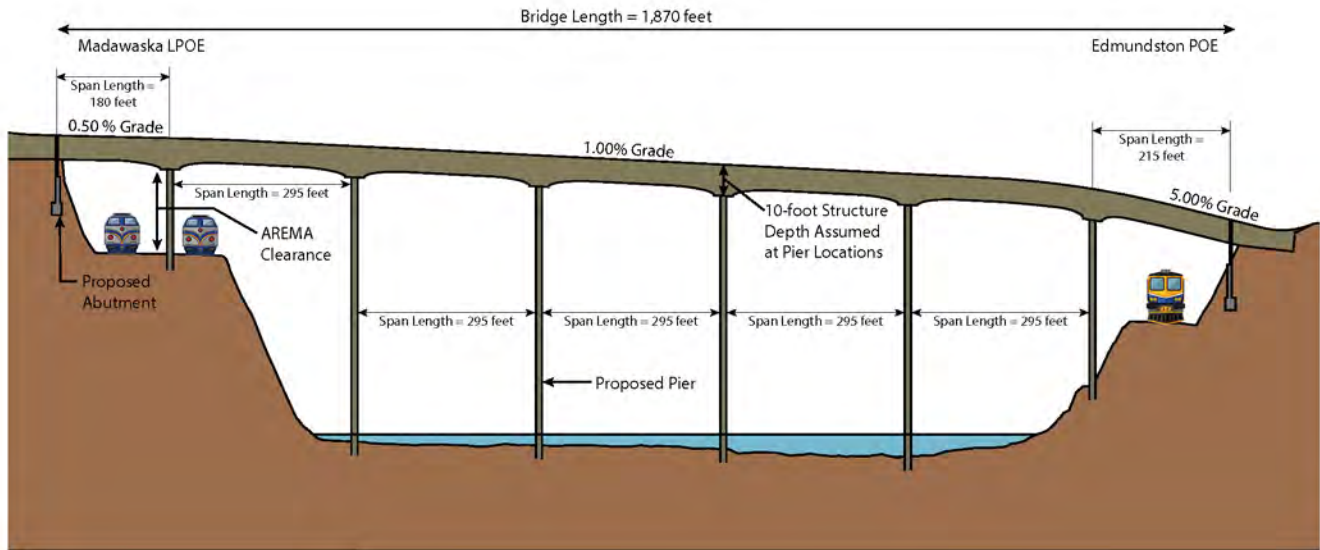
The vertical profile for Bridge Alternative 3 is governed by the required clearance over the CNR rail lines and the need to tie into the new Madawaska LPOE and the existing Edmundston POE.

Bridge Alternative 3 was eliminated from further study because of the cost of construction and the long-term maintenance and construction challenges with a pier between the MNR tracks in Madawaska.

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C. The Preferred Alternative

1. Madawaska Land Port of Entry

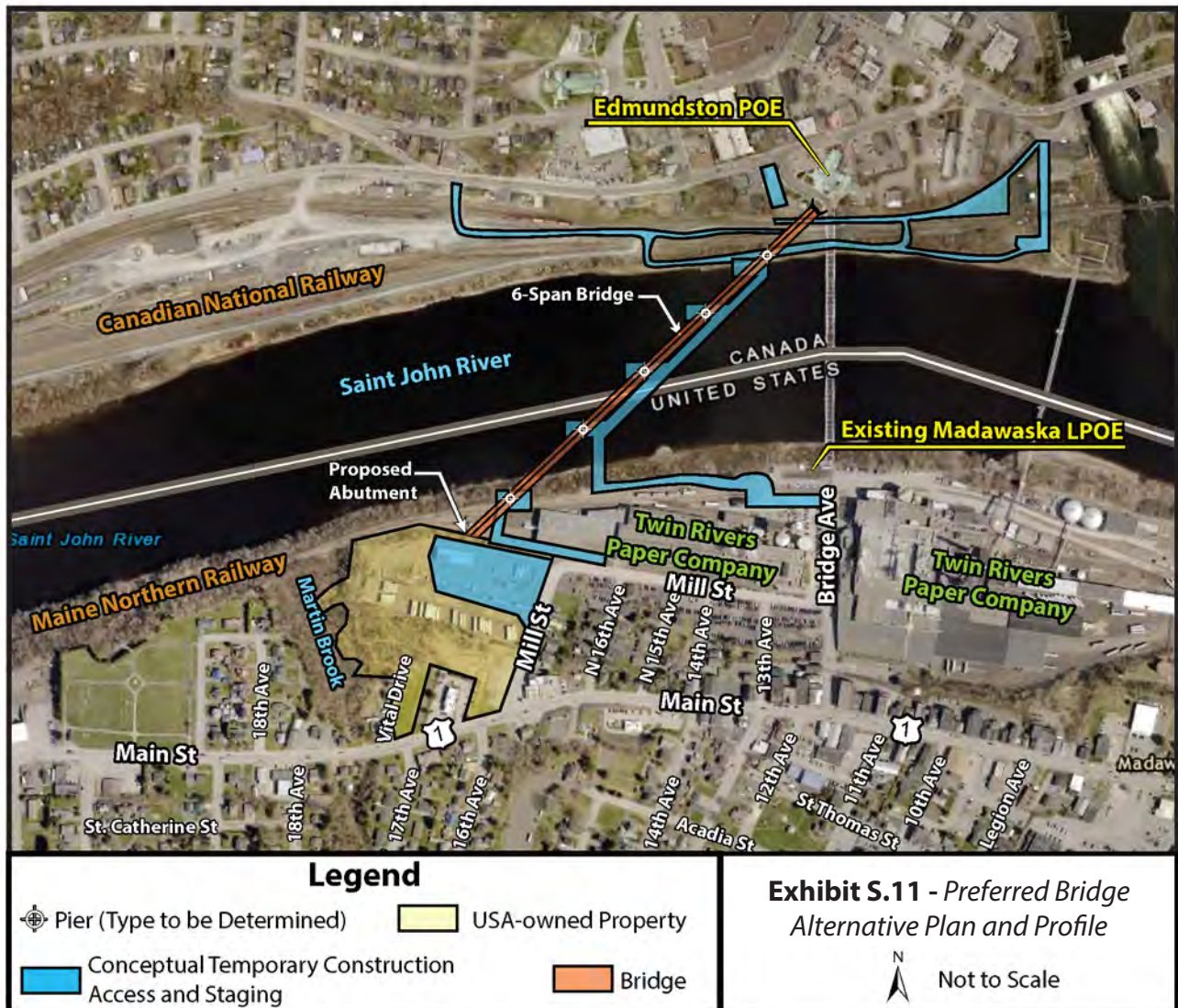
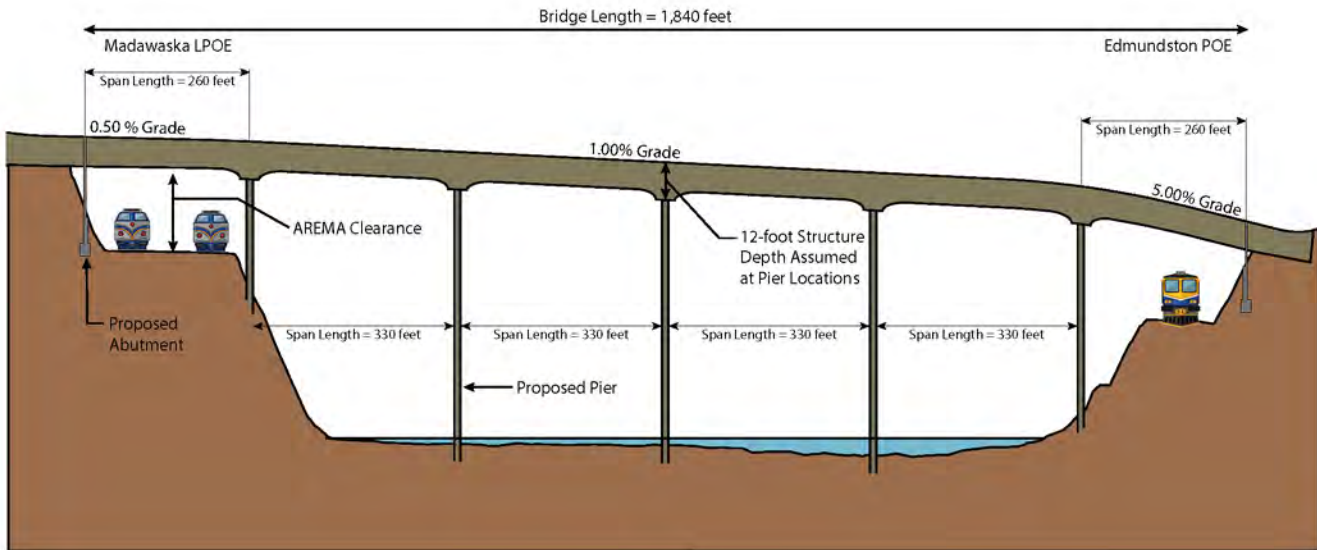
Following the circulation of the DSEIS, LPOE Alternative C was identified as the Preferred LPOE Alternative (Exhibit S.6). LPOE Alternative C was identified as the Preferred LPOE Alternative because it furthers the purpose of the project and satisfies the needs for the project. The Preferred LPOE Alternative:

- Provides enough space for safe and efficient flow of traffic through the LPOE;
- Provides enough space for the operations of the LPOE to function efficiently;
- Meets MaineDOT's access management guidelines and the entrance and exit to the LPOE would be approved by MaineDOT;
- Provides a safer location and distance between the outbound and inbound driveways;
- Provides enough open space to accommodate the necessary length of road to descend from the bridge landing elevation (538) to the elevation of Mill Street (520) without a steep road grade, and provides safer maintenance and circulation in winter conditions;
- Provides increased line of sight, safety and security for CBP personnel to carry out their mission and operations;
- Allows inbound and outbound driveways to connect to Mill Street, eliminating the need for B-trains to use Main Street; and
- Provides enough space for seasonal snow storage and future expansion (MPdL Studio, 2018).

The Preferred Alternative for the LPOE would require the acquisition of additional private property and cause the displacement of residents and a business. The Preferred Alternative for the LPOE would require the acquisition of the McDonald's property and three properties on Vital Drive, one of which is owner-occupied. GSA will acquire the private properties in accordance with the Uniform Relocation Assistance and Real Property Acquisition Policies for Federal and Federally Assisted Programs Act (the Uniform Act). The GSA will offer relocation assistance services, payments, and other eligible benefits in accordance with the policies and provisions in the Uniform Act. However, the GSA has no authority to require McDonald's, or any other displaced party, to relocate within the Town of Madawaska.

2. International Bridge

Following the circulation of the DSEIS, Bridge Alternative 2 was identified as the Preferred Bridge Alternative (Exhibit S.11). Bridge Alternative 2 was identified as the Preferred Bridge Alternative because it furthers the purpose of the project and satisfies the needs for the project. Bridge Alternative 2 is within the corridor for the preferred alternative and uses the maximum number of piers that could be constructed in the river for a worst-case analysis of potential environmental impacts.



Esri, HERE, Garmin, © OpenStreetMap contributors, and the GIS user community, Source: Esri, DigitalGlobe, GeoEye, Earthstar Geographics, CNES/Airbus DS, USDA, USGS, AeroGRID, IGN, and the GIS User Community

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Bridge Alternative 2 was identified as the Preferred Bridge Alternative because, although it would have one more pier in the Saint John River, the piers to support the bridge would be smaller than those with Bridge Alternative 1, decreasing the risks for ice jamming in the river. While Bridge Alternative 2 would have similar construction impacts and comparable costs (both construction and long-term operation and maintenance) to Bridge Alternative 1, Bridge Alternative 2 would take approximately six months less time to construct than Bridge Alternative 1.

D. Affected Environment and Environmental Consequences

LPOE Alternative A would not require the acquisition of private property.

LPOE Alternative B and the Preferred LPOE Alternative would require the acquisition of private property along Main Street and Vital Drive. They both require the acquisition of the McDonald's property, and three Vital Drive properties, one of which is an owner-occupied residence.

The LPOE Alternatives A and B and the Preferred LPOE Alternative would impact approximately 2.6 acres of deciduous trees and shrubs near Martin Brook and the Saint John River. The increased impervious area and stormwater would be addressed during final design to help reduce erosion and sedimentation caused by construction.

Bridge Alternatives 1 and 3 and the Preferred Bridge Alternative would adversely impact the Saint John River, bedrock geology, and aquatic habitat and fisheries due to the construction of bridge piers within the river. Under Alternative 1, two piers would be constructed within the Saint John River. Under Alternative 3, four piers would be constructed within the Saint John River. Under the Preferred Bridge Alternative, three piers would be constructed within the Saint John River. The size of the piers would be determined during final design.

Under Bridge Alternatives 1 and 3 and the Preferred Bridge Alternative, the existing International Bridge would be removed. The removal of the existing International Bridge and piers from the Saint John River would result in a positive impact to the Saint John River.

Bridge Alternatives 1 and 3 and the Preferred Bridge Alternative would result in an adverse effect to the International Bridge which is eligible for listing on the National Register of Historic Places. Under these alternatives, a new bridge would be constructed, and the existing International Bridge would be demolished. A memorandum of agreement has been prepared between the FHWA, MaineDOT, the Advisory Council on Historic Preservation, and Maine Historic Preservation Commission (representing the Maine State Historic Preservation Office) to document the mitigation measures for the adverse effect. To mitigate the adverse effects to the International Bridge, the following measures were stipulated in the MOA:

New Bridge Design Review Process

MaineDOT will consult with the Maine SHPO and the consulting parties on the final design of the new bridge. MaineDOT will provide the SHPO and the consulting parties, for their review and comments, details on aesthetic bridge design features, including public space, viewing, railing and lighting options to ensure compatibility with existing historic features. The information will be provided at 60% and 90% relevant design documents via email and posted on the MaineDOT International Bridge web page. The SHPO and consulting parties will have 30 calendar days to review and provide any comments to MaineDOT.

Historic American Engineering Recordation

MaineDOT will provide recordation of the International Bridge (#2399) in consultation with the National Park Service and in accordance with Historic American Engineering Record (HAER) Level 1 Standards which include Guide to Written Reports for the Historic American Engineering Record (HAER) and the Guide to Preparing HABS/HAER Photographic Documentation (2008, updated December 2017; and 2011, updated June 2015, respectively). Documentation will be prepared by a 36 CFR 61 qualified architectural historian. All materials submitted as documentation will follow the requirements stated by the Heritage Documentation Program and the National Park Service Northeast Regional Office's schedule of documentation. The Maine SHPO will be provided an opportunity of 45 days to review and comment on one draft before the HAER is submitted to the National Park Service to be archived. The Maine SHPO may request a second round of review. National Park Service approval of the completed documentation is required prior to any alteration or demolition of the International Bridge.

Adaptive Reuse or Reuse of Portions of the International Bridge

Prior to dismantling, MaineDOT and the FHWA will offer the International Bridge or a portion of the bridge to any group that could legally take possession of the bridge and maintain it at a new location, provided the group assumes all future legal and financial liability. Costs to induce acceptance of the offer of donation may not exceed the cost to dismantle the bridge. FHWA, the Maine State Historic Preservation Officer and MaineDOT will work jointly to determine the most appropriate use of the existing bridge from any proposals received. If no offers are received for adaptive reuse, then a portion and/or feature of the International Bridge will be retained and offered to the Town of Madawaska and the City of Edmundston. MaineDOT will offer the bridge for adaptive reuse within 60 days after issuance of the ROD which is anticipated in Fall 2019. If no offers are received MaineDOT will coordinate with the Town of Madawaska and the City of Edmundston, New Brunswick on portions of the bridge beginning approximately one month after the offer is published.

The LPOE Alternatives A and B, the Preferred LPOE Alternative, Bridge Alternatives 1 and 3, and the Preferred Bridge Alternative would result in a variety of positive impacts to the flow of traffic. As part of the construction of the LPOE, the portions of

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Mill Street and Main Street adjacent to the LPOE may be reconstructed or reprofiled to provide smooth ingress and egress to the LPOE.

LPOE Alternatives A and B, the Preferred LPOE Alternative, Bridge Alternatives 1 and 3, and the Preferred Bridge Alternative would have a beneficial impact on community cohesion between Madawaska and Edmundston by improving the ease of travel between the two communities. Emergency service providers for the Town of Madawaska and the City of Edmundston would be able to travel across the new bridge in response to emergencies, in fulfillment of their mutual aid emergency service agreement.

LPOE Alternatives A and B, the Preferred LPOE Alternative, Bridge Alternatives 1 and 3, and the Preferred Bridge Alternative would change the visual appearance of the downtown business zone.

There are no other major actions proposed by other government agencies in the study area.

E. Circulation of DSEIS and Summary of Comments Received

Under the Council on Environmental Quality's (CEQ's) regulations implementing NEPA (40 CFR Part 1503.1), an agency that publishes a draft environmental impact statement (DEIS) is required to:

- Obtain the comments of federal agencies with jurisdiction by law or special expertise, and
- Request comments from:
 - » Agencies at all levels of government authorized to develop and enforce environmental standards;
 - » Indian tribes, when the effects may be on a reservation;
 - » An agency that has requested EISs on actions of the kind proposed; and
 - » The public, including actively soliciting comments from those persons or organizations that may be interested or affected.

Comments received can range from statements of support for, or opposition to, an agency's proposed action to detailed critiques of the EIS's analyses and suggestions for new alternatives. Comments might identify factual errors, omissions, areas of controversy, and provide new information to be considered in the analysis of alternatives and prior to decision-making.

An agency's focus in preparing the FSEIS is the consideration of and responses to these comments. The comment-response process includes all steps from receipt and consideration of comments through the preparation of responses and any needed revisions to the EIS. An agency cannot complete the NEPA process until it has

considered and responded to substantive comments on the DSEIS. The comment-response process is intended to help make better and more informed decisions.

The GSA, FHWA, and MaineDOT announced the availability of the *New Madawaska Land Port of Entry and International Bridge Project DSEIS* on December 3, 2018 (Federal Register, Vol. 83, No. 232). A 45-day comment period immediately followed, during which GSA invited federal, state, and local agencies, organizations, and individuals to submit comments on the DSEIS. The comment period on the *New Madawaska U.S. LPOE and International Bridge Project DSEIS* closed on January 31, 2019.

An open house and a public hearing on the DSEIS were held during the 45-day public comment period. The purposes of the open house were to: 1) meet with people with an interest in the study to answer questions about the study, and 2) receive suggestions for further avoidance and minimization of potential impacts of the project and ways to improve the analysis of alternatives prior to decision-making. The purpose of the public hearing was for the public to offer comments on the DSEIS prior to preparation of the FSEIS and decision-making. The open house and public hearing were held on December 12, 2018 at the Madawaska High School and a transcript of the hearing was prepared. Twelve attendees offered substantive comments during the public hearing or immediately following its conclusion.

F. Areas of Controversy

There are no areas of controversy regarding this project.

G. Issues to be Resolved

Issues to be resolved on this project consist of:

- Timing for the relocation of Twin Rivers' utility lines to facilitate the demolition of the existing International Bridge.